



Attend a lecture ...

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The artificial life *by L. Graz*

A number of psychologists have pointed out that one of the problems faced by man in the big city is that his life is no longer adjusted to the rhythm of nature, that his stimuli are no longer the natural ones of water, the earth, the seasons, but rather the technical ones

of the alarm clock, the production schedule and the bus timetable. For these psychologists and for some sociologists, city life can be described as being lived on three distinct planes.

The first is the plane of social life. One example might be found in the family, where the complicated patterns of kinship are dissolved and replaced by the two-generation family unit. Even within this smaller unit, the roles of parents and children tend to become

less clear; how can a father continue to exact absolute obedience from his 18-year-old son who works in a machine shop and earns almost as much as his father? In the city framework, new social institutions are born: contacts on an impersonal level, at the second degree, take the place of direct person-to-person contacts. An example might be that of a representative city council replacing the town meeting. The individual rarely has much control over these groups—he can only submit to them.

The second plane is that of culture. City dwellers often grow up in very different cultures, sometimes with contradictory values. An example which has been given is in Tananarive (Madagascar), where in some classes of the urban proletariat nothing is thought of petty thievery, especially at the expense of people who have more than they need. Something must be done to make people not only understand each other, but learn to live according to approximately the same cultural standards.

The third plane is that of the individual's personality. The many cultural conflicts produce a large proportion of what might be called marginal personalities among city dwellers. A succession of rapid changes in the frame of reference of his life exposes him to serious difficulties. Social scientists call the difficulties resulting from this lack of reference "anomie" and consider it the basis of certain specific mental disorders that are more commonly encountered in large cities, such as schizophrenia.

Escape the crowds ...



Have a meal ...

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